

Scenarios for conference involvement

Currently, **Scenario 1 is being favored** to minimize fiscal exposure, but other options may be explored once the budget is balanced. All scenarios are intended to support long-term partnerships.

Scenario 1: Minimal Involvement – Pure Fiscal Sponsor (Pass-Through)

- **Description:** IONS acts as a 501c3 conduit for funds and donations; Stuart and Abi handle nearly all operations using volunteers and historical processes. IONS takes an administrative fee on inflows. Abi is hired as a consultant or employee. Promotion to IONS members is light or optional.
- **IONS Involvement Level:** Low (primarily accounting/reimbursements; ~1–2 staff part-time)
- **Key Roles / Responsibilities:**
 - IONS (Fiscal Sponsor): Receive and process funds, approve/reimburse expenses, sign major contracts (e.g., hotel)
 - Stuart Hameroff: Support Arnaud Delorme and the committee in curating speakers and program, secure sponsorships
 - Abi (Operations): Day-to-day coordination (registrations, refunds, badges), volunteer management. IONS would not hire Abi, but instead, her salary would be paid by Stuart
 - Arnaud Delorme (Chair): Scientific oversight, UCSD liaison
 - No dedicated IONS production or E&E roles
- **Pros:** Less time and resource drain on IONS; maintains goodwill for potential future partnership; allows quick setup if October is pursued
- **Cons:** IONS still bears contract and financial risk without operational control; high chance of communication chaos; heavy load on finance team (Johnny/Amber); limited mission impact
- **Estimated Financial Risk (Worst Case):** \$250K Loss (if no sponsorships come through and attendance is low)
- **Additional Notes from Discussions:** We may want a guarantee of name/brand rights for any involvement to make it worth it for IONS to take the risk.

Scenario 2: Moderate – Fiscal Sponsor + Limited Production Support

- **Description:** IONS handles funds and key contracts plus some enhancements (e.g., app improvements, programmatic tweaks, IONS-branded experiences/booth). Abi is hired as a consultant or employee. October reboot possible with similar program.
- **IONS Involvement Level:** Medium (~3–4 IONS staff part-time; limited E&E lift)
- **Key Roles / Responsibilities:**
 - IONS (Conference Runner): Full financial underwriting, manage registrations/refunds, oversee limited production enhancements; **name/brand rights transfer required**
 - Stuart Hameroff: Program curation lead, speaker invites/reconfirmations, sponsorship outreach (must be verified)
 - Abi: Full production of conference as she has run it in the past as a hired IONS consultant
 - Arnaud Delorme (Chair) & Thomas Brophy : Scientific committee, programmatic improvements (e.g., ethics, diversity focus, psi)
 - External Vendors: Commotion Studios (AV/live stream), production company (stage/announcements)
 - UCSD: host website, faculty on the science committee
- **Pros:** Balances risk and reward; tests long-term partnership potential; adds some IONS visibility and programmatic value
- **Cons:** Still diverts significant resources (especially E&E/Pillar 3); high risk of scope creep and communication chaos in rushed October timeline; moderate distraction for Andrea and team
- **Estimated Financial Risk (Worst Case):** \$250K (includes production costs; hotel commitments if no sponsorships and if attendance is low)
- **Additional Notes from Discussions:** Weaker fit for fall due to rush and distraction; potentially better suited for delayed April 2027+ reboot with more planning time

Scenario 3: High – Full Conference Runner (Long-Term Partnership)

- **Description:** IONS takes full ownership as conference runner with complete production control. Shift preferred to April 2027 or later for updated program and integration of IONS mission elements (e.g., noetic sciences flavor). Secure long-term MOU with UCSD and Stuart.
- **IONS Involvement Level:** High (full team involvement; hire dedicated conference lead to protect existing projects)
- **Key Roles / Responsibilities:**
 - IONS (Conference Runner): Own all operations, finances, IP (recordings); marketing push; integrate subtle IONS branding/experiences; **name/brand rights transfer + long-term MOU essential**
 - Stuart Hameroff: Advisory role, initial program input, knowledge transition
 - Abi: Hired as IONS consultant or employee for continuity

- Thomas Brophy / Arnaud Delorme / Cassi Vieten: Co-chairs, program evolution (e.g., refresh speakers for freshness)
- Helané Wahbeh / Kerstin Sjoquist / Andrea Livingston: Full programmatic and production oversight; align with IONS strategy
- UCSD: Long-term academic partner (website hosting, program input)
- External Vendors / Volunteers: Full AV/production support, on-site help
- **Pros:** Maximizes mission impact and strategic asset value; potential revenue from recordings; builds multi-year partnership
- **Cons:** High resource commitment; significant delay if not rushing fall; requires Stuart's full buy-in for brand transfer, could alienate traditional materialists in the conference if IONS brand is too heavily represented in the conference.
- **Estimated Financial Risk (Worst Case):** \$250K loss plus an additional 200K in staff time

Scenario 4: Alternative – Decline Production This Fall + High-Level Sponsor Only (or Delay to Future)

- **Description:** IONS declines to produce or underwrite the fall reboot; offers light sponsorship (e.g., \$20K, booth, branding). Continue discernment talks for April 2027 or later. Let Stuart pursue alternatives (e.g., Santa Barbara with Jay/Ben). Prototype independent IONS online community event.
- **IONS Involvement Level:** None to Low (sponsorship only)
- **Key Roles / Responsibilities:**
 - IONS (Sponsor): Provide branding/booth/experiences; no financial underwriting or contracts; **continue name/brand rights discussions for future partnership**
 - Stuart Hameroff / Abi / Alternatives (e.g., Jay Sanguinetti, Ben Tanner): Full control and production
 - Thomas Brophy / Arnaud Delorme: Ideally continued involvement in science committee
 - No IONS production or operational roles
- **Pros:** Zero financial/operational risk; frees all resources for aligned IONS work (Pillar 3, online community prototype); avoids rushed chaos
- **Cons:** Misses immediate partnership opportunity; potential short-term goodwill strain with Stuart; limited influence this year
- **Estimated Financial Risk (Worst Case):** \$0–\$50K (sponsorship fee only)
- **Additional Notes from Discussions:** Delay allows full discernment time; name rights remain a future gating condition if talks continue